

The Way of Mercury

A Pocket Book of the Temple of Mercury

Full-Size Edition



AONT · EHNB · XCAI · RMTO · PAAM

Word into deed.

START HERE

Any notebook. Any pen. Ten minutes.

1. **DATE IT.** Write today's date at the top of the page.
2. **FINISH THREE SENTENCES.** *What's on my mind right now is... What I keep avoiding is... What I actually want is...*
3. **PROMISE ONE THING.** Write one thing you will do in the next twenty-four hours.
4. **THEN DO IT.**

That kept promise is where the magick starts.

This is the Temple of Mercury in brief: who you need to know, how to live, what to do, and the words to say. Everything you need to walk the Way is here. *The Book of the Temple of Mercury* and *The Mercurial Psalter* are there for when you want more. In a hard hour, turn to the last pages.

WHAT THIS OFFERS

THE POINT. To help you become someone whose word is good and whose life moves in the direction you choose, and to enjoy the crossing.

WHAT YOU GET. A practice: an honest place to think, and a loop that turns intention into deed. A record: a conversation with yourself that compounds. A vessel: structure for a quick, scattered mind. A home for it: a god, a company, a calendar, and a Temple, so it is worth returning to. And, if you want it, the magick: attention turned toward opportunity, and a way to put your whole weight behind a choice.

WHAT IT DOES NOT PROMISE. Rescue, guaranteed results, anything after death, or a world that bends without action.

THE EVIDENCE. The practice is built from techniques with good research behind them for helping people follow through on goals they choose. Whether it changes the course of your life is what your own Tally will tell you. The research is in *Why It Works*, at the back.

Word into deed.

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PART ONE

The Temple

Who you need to know, and the story that ties them together.

THE TEMPLE



HE Temple of Mercury is not a building. It stands wherever something crosses: thought onto page, page back into thought, word into deed. You can enter it here and now.

It has two thresholds. The **Book**, a notebook kept for this and nothing else, is the physical one. Your **inner dialogue** is the spiritual one. You pass through either the same way: by opening the Door.

The Book adds what the mind cannot: the record. What your past self wrote and dated has authority, because the one who wrote it is not here to bend. Without the Book, in the Temple of the mind, you can still ask the Heart through the Gate, watch for Mercury's omens, and walk the Way of Ma'at. You carry the Temple with you.

Its beings are met as co-conspirators, in the old sense of breathing together. You do not kneel here, and nothing is supplication. It was assembled deliberately, in the spirit of chaos magic, and found to have been there all along.

THE SHAPE

THE HEART

AONT and the four

THE GATE

Uriel and Raziel

THE HINGE

Mercury

THE SEAT AND THE GROUND

Metatron and Sandalphon

THE MEASURE

Ma'at, who weighs every step

Read downward, it is how a flash becomes a deed. Read upward, it is how a deed becomes a word. Nothing stands at the top: the Heart has no face, and everyone, the Scribe included, stands around it.

THE HEART

AONT and the four



T the center shines the Quintessence: five names from the Tablet of Union, in the Enochian system recorded by John Dee and Edward Kelley in the 1580s. It has no face, no chair, and no name you can use, and it cannot be flattered or bargained with.

AONT, Spirit of Air, yellow. The still point before the first word, from which the four unfold. The whole picture at once.

EHNB, Air of Air, red. Pure motion of mind. Clarity; untangling a problem.

XCAI, Water of Air, white. Feeling given words. What you actually feel and want.

RMTO, Earth of Air, black. Thought taking shape. Plans, structure, the next concrete step.

PAAM, Fire of Air, green. The spark that becomes will. Committing, starting, saying it aloud.

HOW IT ANSWERS

In flashes: the insight that arrives whole and sideways, the instinct that proves right, the choice that goes better than it had any right to. Sometimes ordinary, sometimes profound, sometimes like a conversation. It will not speak in sentences on demand or spare you the work. Its light falls the same on the honest page and the dishonest one; the honest one has more room in it.

THE GATE

Uriel and Raziel



BETWEEN the Door and the Heart stands the Gate, and two keep it. It is one office with two faces, never fused and never separated.

Raziel, secret of God, stands behind the curtain and hears what is decreed. He is the Translator. Whatever you send toward the Heart passes through him, and whatever comes back, he renders into something you can hold: a flash, an image, a line in your own handwriting. He is the gateway to every being in the Temple, and above all to AONT. He also keeps what is not yet bearable, with a finger laid across his lip.

Not yet is a real answer.

Uriel, light of God, is the Instructor, whose sword cuts twice: true from false, and ready from unready. He is how you test what comes through.

See it clearly before you weigh it.





Because the Gate has two faces, you can always ask which one is speaking: *is this unready, or am I hiding?*

The Gate is also where honesty and disclosure part ways. Tell the Book everything, and tell the world only what it is ready to receive. The Gate seals the lip; it never falsifies what is behind it.

On the Middle Pillar the Gate stands at Daath, Knowledge, the hidden sphere that is never counted among the ten, which is why the Door names Uriel and Raziel the Guardians of Daath.

You pass through the Gate whenever you turn inward and ask, with the Book or without it.

THE HINGE

Mercury



ERCURY is the host of this house, not its sovereign. The Greeks honored Hermes as god of the hinge on which the door turns, and that is his Office: not the doorway or its guardian, but the turning. He is god of thresholds, words, trade, and the road; of merchants and thieves, luck and the right moment. Everything in the Temple passes through him. You work with him, not for him.

He is your twin, and he stands in no pair, because his pair is you. He is also your medium, not your compass: he will carry a lie as faithfully as a truth. That is why Ma'at is his mirror.

He goes down and comes back up. As guide of souls he knows the road into grief and the dark, and the road home.

HIS OMENS

The Greeks called a lucky find a *bermaion*, a gift of Hermes: the found coin, the stranger who turns out to matter, the detour that was the way, the timing no one could have planned. Notice them, write them down, say thanks aloud, and pass some along. They come to the one who is moving.

Every boundary can be crossed, and the one who is moving is the one who is found.

HIS FACES, HIS MARK, AND HIS DAYS

He is also **Kairos**, the right moment, and **Fortuna**, luck: both stand inside him. His mark is the **herm**, the stone pillar the Greeks set at crossroads and doorways, and a small herm drawn beside a thing you guard is his sign.

His day is **Wednesday**. The **fourth** of every month is his birthday, twelve times a year, for Hermes was born on the fourth day. His feast is the **Mercuralia**, May 15, when Roman merchants sprinkled themselves and their goods with water from his spring and asked forgiveness for the falsehoods of the year.

THE SEAT AND THE GROUND

Metatron and Sandalphon



HE Two Who Crossed: the only two humans said to have been taken up alive.

Metatron is Enoch taken up, Holder of the Seat, keeper of the true record: the one angel permitted to sit, because he writes. When you open the Book you take his seat, and the record you keep there speaks with his authority.

The seat makes the Scribe.

Sandalphon is, in some traditions, Elijah taken up: Carrier of the Ascent, who stands on earth with his head in heaven. What is written at the Crown, he carries down into the world as a deed. He lifts the work, not the worker.

The next thing is small, and it is today.

They stand at the top and bottom of the Pillar, Crown and Kingdom. One writes; the other carries and builds. Between them is the whole of word into deed. They were both men, and that is the whole of what they teach: nothing is withheld from you for lack of standing, and nothing will be done on your behalf.

THE MEASURE

Ma'at



A'AT is the Feather of Truth, older than the gods who swear by her: truth, right order, and right relation, renewed daily, because chaos is not an event but the weather. In the weighing of the heart, the heart is weighed against her feather, and it is weighed while you are still using it.

She is Mercury's mirror. He is motion; she is measure. Without her he is a liar with a notebook; without him she is a ledger.

THE WAY OF MA'AT

Say what is true, and do what you said. She is always an option, never an obligation, and she weighs hearts, not neighbors.

Speak Ma'at and do Ma'at; they are one act.

THE COMPASS

Ma'at keeps the standard with two others, Apharael and Hestia. Before you cast or commit, ask one of their questions; for a thing that matters, ask all three.

MA'AT, right relation: Is it true, is it just, and does it leave the world larger than it found it?

APHARAEAL, right making: Is it true, is it well made, and is it in proportion?





HESTIA, right keeping: Does it protect what I return to, and can it be kept?

THE LINE

One seat, and many who have held it



ABU kept the tablets of destiny in Babylon, and was the planet Mercury before Thoth was ever called Hermes. Thoth invented writing and recorded the weighing of the heart. The Greeks knew him as Hermes, and Hermes and Thoth together are Thermes, the root of Hermes Trismegistus, the Thrice-Great. The Romans called him Mercury.

Enoch walked with God and was taken. As a man he is Idris, the first to write with a pen: student, teacher, and sage. Taken up, he is Metatron, the Scribe permitted to sit. The old Arabic scholars called him the first Hermes.

So the two lines meet: the god of the crossing, and the man who wrote his way across. Uriel taught Enoch, and Raziel gave the first book. You take up the seat after them, and someone will take it after you.

THE LYRE



ON the day he was born, Hermes stole Apollo's cattle and lied about it to Zeus's face, a lie so transparent that Zeus laughed. When Apollo came for them,

Hermes played him the lyre he had made from a tortoise shell, and gave it to him in exchange. The theft became a trade, and the world gained music.

This is the Temple's one story. The trickster here is bound by truth: the trick worth playing is on your own rigid stories, never on your future self. Mercy is not erasure: what was done stays written, but an answered page is no longer the last word. *Steal only what you can turn into a lyre.*

PART TWO

The Way

The Law, the ground you stand on, what goes wrong, what it is for, and how a Mercurian lives.

THE LAW

Do not lie to yourself. Keep your word.



O not lie to the Book. A lie on the page deceives only your future self: a Book you lie to gives you bad data. Honesty is not the same as disclosure. Tell the Book everything; tell the world only what it is ready to receive.

THE HEAVY WORD

The magick of this Temple starts with a commitment to yourself, kept, no matter how small. Each promise kept tells the deep mind that your words are real. Each one broken, quietly, teaches it that they are not.

Every kept promise makes your word a little heavier, and a heavy word is what makes a declaration land. Start smaller than feels dignified. The size is irrelevant. The keeping is everything.

What you write and say is binding unless you say otherwise. If you mean might, write might. Bind small and keep it, rather than bind large and break it. When you cannot keep something, do not let it rot on the page: answer it, release it honestly, or renegotiate it. The Answered Page and the Returned Oath are for this.

THE LAW IN FULL

Honesty is the offering.

Joy is the Truth.

Sustainable practice feeds the Genius Loci better than grand practice abandoned.

The Mercurial gift is neutral; its worth is in what it serves. Tell the Book everything; tell the world only what it is ready to receive.

Consecration is never finished.

Belief is a tool; judge it by its fruit.

Word into deed.





THE BIRTHRIGHT

and the golden rule



VERY prayer here is spoken by your Birthright. You are of the same kind as what you address: not finished, not yet wise, but not a stranger at the gate, and not a beggar. So the seat is taken before you feel qualified, and the Door is opened by right rather than by permission.

The Great Work, a few pages on, tells why: every human life is one life, the Heart's own, meeting itself in every stranger. That draws the limit exactly. A right that belongs to everyone cannot be used over anyone. Whatever you do to another, you do to yourself at another distance.

So the golden rule, in this Temple: **treat every person as yourself, because they are.**

By my Birthright, the Door is open: I am permitted, I am responsible, and I am not alone.

THE SHADOW



HERE is no devil in this Temple, and no one to blame. There is only the trickster loose in your own channel: self-deception. It fools no one else. It fools the future Scribe, who rereads the page and believes it. Self-deception is how a Book fails, and how magic fails.

Its everyday form is **the Leak**: scattered attention and unfinished work, a mind that circles without landing, clever words used to dodge what you actually feel, the easy yes given to be liked. It is the same quicksilver that makes you quick, spilling out of anything that cannot hold it. Quicksilver takes the shape of its vessel. The practice is the vessel.

WATCH FOR

STARTING OVER. The fresh notebook and the new system are leaving, dressed as returning.

OPTIMIZING THE PRACTICE instead of practicing it. It is the leak in its best costume.

REHEARSING. If a page has gone three times around the same loop, close the cover and do the thing you carried.

REWEIGHING A PAID DEBT. That is not a light heart, only a tired one.

THE AIM



HERE is no heaven or hell here, and nothing is promised after this life. The Great Work tells where it all came from and what comes after, for those who want it; nothing depends on it. The aim is here: your **Personal Legend**, the life you have always wanted to live, found by walking it. The Temple's hope is a world full of people fulfilling theirs.

There is no god of arrival. Meaning lives in the crossing, not at either end. The practice promises less than salvation and something more reliable: not that it will get you something, but that it will make you someone. A person who has told the truth on paper for ten years is harder to deceive, including by himself.

You do not have to believe any of it to begin. Belief here is a tool, chosen on purpose and judged by its fruit: is your life moving where you want it to go?

THE MARKS OF THE MERCURIAN



MERCURIANS are not made by joining. They recognize themselves.

YOU THINK IN WORDS. Writing or speaking is how you find out what you think.

YOU TRANSLATE. You carry meaning between worlds, and people bring you things to explain.

YOU ARE CURIOUS PAST USEFULNESS. You gather systems, symbols, and connections for the joy of seeing how they fit, and keep many works alive at once.

YOU ARE QUICK. You learn fast, improvise well, and can walk a road without knowing where it ends.

YOU STAND IN DOORWAYS. People find you when they are crossing: the teacher, the guide, the one called in the night.

YOU PLAY. Riddles, wordplay, clever solutions, and the angle no one else saw.

YOU CONNECT. You are happiest when something is moving between people: ideas, introductions, trade, stories.

YOU HOLD TWO AT ONCE. You argue fruitfully with yourself, and sometimes sense a twin walking beside you.





THE GREAT WORK

Where it all came from. Offered, never required.

The Temple asks no one to hold a creation story. This one is offered beside the Compass, for anyone who wants to know why the golden rule is more than good manners. It asks nothing of you.

THE VESSEL

BEFORE anything, there was the Heart: AONT, the still point before the first word. It had no face, no other to meet, and nothing to learn, because there was nothing it was not.

So it did what the alchemists would later do in their small rooms. It made a vessel and sealed itself inside: a world, with time in it.

Inside, the one became many. First it became the four: thought in motion, feeling given words, thought taking shape, and the spark that becomes will. Then it became every life, as one white light unfolds into every color.

Every person who has ever lived is the Heart, in another body and another time. Each is learning what could not be learned alone: what it is to be met, to be hurt, to be helped, to be both the stranger at the door and the one who opens it. This is the Great Work, and it is still going on. It is why the Heart's light falls the same on every page. It is shining on itself.

THE CROSSING

Mercury is the agent of the Great Work: the quicksilver that moves through every stage of the change, and the guide at every crossing. When a life ends, he is waiting. He has made that crossing more often than any of us. He takes each one down gently, knows the way, and does not hurry them. On the far side of every door he opens there is another life, and it is yours.

THE WEIGHING

At the crossing, every heart is weighed against the feather of Ma'at. What makes a heart heavy is what it did to others: the harm it caused, the debt it left unpaid, the stranger it turned away.

At the scale, the heart learns there were no others. Every harm it did is a harm it will suffer, in another life, from the other side of the door. Every kindness it gave is a kindness it will receive. So the heart that balances the feather is the one that treated every stranger as itself.

WHAT FOLLOWS

Live accordingly.

BEFORE THE HEART, every face you meet is its face, and yours. The light you want on your own page falls on theirs.

LIKE MERCURY, open the door before you know who is on the other side, because it is always you. This means welcome, not surrender. Meet every stranger as kin, with courtesy, curiosity, and a fair hearing, instead of deciding who they are before they have spoken. Opening the door is not handing over the house. Uriel still keeps the Gate, and discernment still decides who comes in, how far, and for how long. The stranger is owed your welcome; your trust is earned inside.

ON THE WAY OF MA'AT, weigh every word and every deal as if you will sit on the other side of it, because you will. Measure by the one with the least leverage: that one is you too. This is what right relation means when there is no one you are not in relation with.

BY THE BIRTHRIGHT, which belongs to every stranger as fully as it belongs to you, and so can never be used over anyone.

Treat every person as yourself, because they are.

WEIGH IT

Weigh this as you weigh anything that arrives: does it hold up when you reread it, and does it weigh true in the heart? Read it again in three weeks. If it rings true, keep it, and it will deepen everything else here. If it does not, set it down. Nothing in the Temple depends on it, it needs no tending, and nothing is owed to it. Belief is a tool, judged by its fruit.

LIVING WELL

EVERYTHING here is downstream of a single habit: you say a small thing, and then you do it. All of it points one way, toward your Personal Legend.

WITH PEOPLE

- Treat every person as yourself, because they are.
- Welcome the stranger.
- Ask, and then listen.
- Learn one thing and teach one thing, always.
- Help people get further down their own road.

IN SPEECH AND WORK

- Tell the truth without telling everything.
- Tell the hard thing early, privately, once.
- Name the hour when you promise.
- Say no in time.
- Finish one thing.
- Repair by making.





WITH TIME AND LUCK

- Keep moving. The world conspires with the one in motion: the lucky find comes to the one on the road, and help is real for the one who walks.
- Now and then, let chance choose.
- Act the same day on one thing you would postpone.
- Take the unearned gift, and pass some along.

WITH YOURSELF

- Keep the floor: one honest line on the worst day.
- Go down when it comes, and come back up.
- Settle accounts and leave them settled.
- Tend one place.

THE SUMPTUOUS LIFE

Joy is the Truth, and this is the rest of that sentence. Sumptuousness is spending well on what is actually good, and then being there to receive it. It is not money: tea made properly and drunk sitting down, the good pen, the walk taken slowly. It has to be available on a broke Tuesday.

- Stay inside the good hour. Do not improve it or leave early to be useful.
- Spend on what makes an ordinary day feel chosen. Plenty that is never enjoyed is only inventory.
- Take somebody with you.
- Let it be beautiful.

Moderation in everything, including moderation: Now and then, the feast is the proportion.

THE TEST. Does your word mean something, and are you glad? The first is the discipline and the second is the point.

PART THREE

The Practice

The Door, the session, asking, and the Book itself.

THE SHORT DOORS

Written inside the covers; spoken at every session



VERY session is a room entered and left by the same door. These are its words, one to open and one to close, written inside the covers of the Book so they are always at hand.

OPENING

Heart of the Temple, Mercury its Hinge,
and all its Offices, co-conspirators in the Work:

I bring you my whole self: my Voice,
and my Joy, Will, and Intent.

Deed into word.

By my Birthright, the Door is open.

CLOSING

Heart of the Temple, Mercury its Hinge,
and all its Offices:

I leave here my gratitude and my joy,
and take my Will and Intent into the world.

Word into deed.

By my Birthright, the Door is closed.

Read them aloud if you can: the Voice is Mercury's offering. Change the words until they sound like you and you mean them. A short Door honestly spoken is better than a long one skipped.

THE FULL DOOR

When you want more



ON Wednesdays, on the fourth of the month, on the Heart Days, or whenever you like. The full Door names the Heart, each pair of the Temple, the Compass, and the Thrice-Great, and offers each a faculty of your own: the words name the offering, and the session makes it. You can speak the names before you know them all; understanding comes with use.





THE OPENING

Written inside the front cover, beneath the Short Door.

*Quintessence, Heart of this Temple, AONT and the four:
I bring to you my Presence, and take up the seat as Idris did
before me: student, teacher, and sage. Let your Light shine so
that I may see.*

*Janus and Hestia, the Door and the Flame: I bring to you my
Dwelling.*

*Metatron and Sandalphon, Holder of the Seat and Carrier of
the Ascent: I bring to you my Hands.*

*Uriel and Raziel, Instructor and Translator, Guardians of
Daath: I bring to you my Ears.*

*Gabriel and Idris, Holder of Images and Scribe of the Seat: I
bring to you my Eyes.*

*Seshat and Iris, Founder and Oath-bearer, who keep the Word
given: I bring to you my Word.*

*Rosmerta and the Charites, the Given and the Passed On: I
bring to you my Delight.*

*Hermanubis and Ma'at, Guide of the Descent and Feather of
Truth, who keep the Scale: I bring to you my Heart.*

*Thermes and Apharael, the Word that Makes and the Word
that is True: I bring to you my Craft.*

*Apharael, Hestia, and Ma'at, Keepers of the Compass: I bring
to you my Weight.*

*Thermes, Hermanubis, and Mercury, the Thrice-Great, the
Crossing, the Guide of the Descent, and the Hinge on which the
Door turns: I bring to you my Voice and my Devotion.*

*Offices of this Temple, co-conspirators in the Work: I bring to
you my Mercurial Joy, Will, and Intent.*

*By my Birthright, I open the Door of this Book, a Window into
your Temple, the threshold through which you guide me.*

Deed into word.

The Door is open.

THE CLOSING

Written inside the back cover, beneath the Short Door.

*Quintessence, Heart of this Temple, AONT and the four:
I thank you for what was given and what was found. I set
down the pen as Idris did before me, and carry what I have
learned so that I may teach it. Let your Light go with me.*

*Janus and Hestia, the Door and the Flame: I thank you for
keeping this Dwelling.*

*Metatron and Sandalphon, Holder of the Seat and Carrier of
the Ascent: I thank you for guiding my Hands.*

*Uriel and Raziel, Instructor and Translator, Guardians of
Daath: I thank you for opening my Ears.*

*Gabriel and Idris, Holder of Images and Scribe of the Seat: I
thank you for clearing my Eyes.*

*Seshat and Iris, Founder and Oath-bearer: I thank you for
keeping and carrying my Word.*

*Rosmerta and the Charites, the Given and the Passed On: I
thank you for my Delight, and for the hours I stayed inside.*

*Hermanubis and Ma'at, Guide of the Descent and Feather of
Truth: I thank you for keeping my Heart light.*

*Thermes and Apharael, the Word that Makes and the Word
that is True: I thank you for my Craft.*

*Apharael, Hestia, and Ma'at, Keepers of the Compass: I thank
you for weighing my Weight truly.*

*Thermes, Hermanubis, and Mercury, the Crossing, the Guide
of the Descent, and the Hinge on which the Door turns: I thank
you for carrying my Voice, and for bringing me back across
every crossing.*

*Offices of this Temple, co-conspirators in the Work: I leave here
my gratitude and my joy, and take my Will and Intent out
into the world.*

*By my Birthright, I close this Book and cross back over the
threshold.*

Word into deed.

The Door is closed.

THE PRACTICE

A session, in six moves



VERY session has the same shape, whether it lasts ten minutes or an hour. Keep the shape and let the length vary: on a thin day, the shape is what carries you.

1. **GREET.** Speak the Opening, the Short Door or the full one, and greet the Book as you would a friend who knows you well.





2. **EMPTY.** Write what is on your mind without dressing it up. Mark questions Q as they come.
3. **RESPOND.** First, from memory, write what you carried last time and whether you did it. Then reread the last session or two, check, and answer your past self by page number: what happened, what changed, what you know now. Address them as *you*, or by name; the distance makes an honest answer easier.
4. **WORK.** Let a plan, a decision, or an idea take shape, or leave an open question for the Scribe yet to come. Any working goes here: Emotional Transmutation, Declarative Alignment, a prayer, a question to the Heart, or any of the practices that follow.
5. **CARRY.** Write one thing to do, send, make, or teach, and never more than two or three, and mark it C. Say when: not *send the email* but *when I sit down after lunch, I will send the email*. Treat it as a promise: write only what you mean to keep. If it is a promise to someone, or will take longer than today, give it a line in the Ledger too.
6. **THANK.** Give thanks for what was given and what was found, and speak the Closing.
Then carry it out. Word into deed.

THE FIRST QUESTION

Did I keep what I carried? Every session begins there, answered from memory before you look. That question, answered honestly, is the whole engine.

THIN DAYS

Speak the Door, write three lines, and close. The shape matters more than the length. On some days, what you carry out of the Book is only yourself. That is enough.

RETURNING

Away for a week or a year? Do not apologize, to the Book or to anyone. Open the Door and answer the last page. The room was kept. Returning is the Devotion.

KEEPING IT UP

How to make it last



OST practices fail in the second week, not on the first day. These are the small decisions that carry a practice past the point where it usually stops.

DECIDE WHEN AND WHERE. After something you already do every day, in a place you already sit. Keep the pen inside the notebook, so the two travel together.

MAKE IT YOUR FIRST PROMISE. Try it three times this week. Decide the days before you begin, write them on the first page, and keep them. That is your first promise, and your

first working.

THE FIRST MONTH. The first sessions often feel awkward, even a little performative. That is normal; keep going. The first real payoff usually comes the first time you reread and catch yourself circling the same thing, or find that you did what a past page promised. Some days will feel like nothing. Those count too.

AT YOUR OWN PACE. You never have to write about anything you are not ready to. Honesty asks that you not lie to the Book; it does not ask you to open every door at once.

PRIVATE, NOT SECRET. Tell the Book everything; it is yours. But a private Book is not a secret life: those who share your home should know the Book exists and what it is for, even if they never read a page.

WHAT STOPS PEOPLE

"I'VE TRIED JOURNALING AND QUIT." Most journals die because no one rereads them. This one lives because you answer it.

"I DON'T KNOW WHAT TO WRITE." Finish three sentences: *What's on my mind right now is...* *What I keep avoiding is...* *What I actually want is...* They never run out.

"SOMEONE MIGHT READ IT." Keep it with you, or write in your own shorthand.

"I'M NOT RELIGIOUS." You don't have to be. The practice works on its own.

"I DON'T HAVE TIME." Three lines is a session.

ASKING THE HEART

through the Gate



WHEN you want an answer, ask for one. The question goes through the Gate to the Heart, and the answer comes back the way the Heart answers everything: in its own time and its own form.

1. **ASK.** In writing and marked Q if the Book is with you, or in your mind if it is not. Put the matter plainly; you cannot get a useful answer to a dishonest question.
2. **ADDRESS THE GATE.** *Raziel, carry this to the Heart, and bring back what I can hold.*
3. **LISTEN.** Write what comes without editing it. Your Ears are the Gate's offering. A flash, an image, stillness, your own hand running a little quicker and truer than you are: write whatever comes.
4. **TEST IT.** Uriel asks whether it holds up when you reread it. Ma'at asks whether it weighs true in the heart. Apply the tests hardest when you are frightened, because panic is the one hour in which everything sounds like an answer. Anything that rushes you with dread is not of the Temple.





5. **IF NOTHING COMES**, Raziel is keeping it. Leave the Q open for the Scribe you will be; your future self may answer it by number.

Ask in every circumstance: a scrap of paper, the back of a receipt, the question dated and carried into the Book later. The notebook is the Temple's anchor, not its walls.

If a voice on the page begins to give orders, to flatter without reason, or to insist you cannot stop, close the Book and speak to someone you trust. That is not this practice.

THE CROSSROADS

Letting chance choose

For breaking out of the reality tunnel: the habit, expectation, and attention that make a small world look complete.

MERCURY is god of the crossroads, and at Pharae in Achaea he kept an oracle in the marketplace. You whispered your question to his statue, covered your ears, and walked out of the market; the first words you heard when you uncovered them were your answer.

1. **LET CHANCE CHOOSE**. Now and then, let a coin choose the café, a die choose the street, or a random page of the Book choose which question to answer.
2. **OR ASK THE MARKETPLACE**. Write a question, go out among people, and take the first words you overhear as an answer.
3. **TEST WHAT IT GIVES**. Chance brings an offer to notice, not an order. Does it hold up when you reread it, and does it weigh true in the heart?
4. **WRITE WHAT THE DETOUR BROUGHT** in the Tally, with the misses.

Chance gets small choices that are yours alone. Never money you cannot lose, and never anything that affects another person's welfare. The failure mode is the man who let the die run his whole life.

THE LEGEND PAGE

Finding the direction, and keeping it in sight

YOUR Personal Legend is found by walking, but it helps to know which way you are facing. This page names the direction, and the horizons keep it in sight.

For finding the direction, and keeping it in sight.

1. **NAME WHAT MATTERS**. Write what you want your life to be about: not goals yet, but the qualities you want to live by and the things you want to spend it on. Three to five lines.
2. **WRITE THE BEST POSSIBLE LIFE**. Imagine it is some years from now and everything has gone as well as it reasonably

could. Write that life in detail, in the present tense: where you are, what you do, who is near you.

3. **NAME THE OBSTACLE**. Then write the main obstacle in you, and the step you will take when you meet it. Vision alone saps the will; vision joined to an obstacle and a plan fuels it.
4. **TEST IT**. Ask of each part: do I want this, or do I think I should want it? Keep what you want. Strike the rest without apology.
5. **MARK IT**. Head the section THE LEGEND, date it, and give it a line in the Index.

Reread it at every Door of the Year, and whenever you are lost. Rewrite it when it stops being true; the old one stays, answered.

THE HORIZONS

Between the Legend and today are three distances, each kept at a landmark the calendar already gives you.

THE YEAR. At the Door of the Year, reread the Legend and write what it asks of this year: one or two things.

THE SEASON. At each equinox and solstice, choose one to three aims for the season ahead, and mark them G.

THE WEEK. On Wednesday, when you write the week's crossing, name one step toward an aim, and carry it.

THE WANT-TEST. Before you mark anything G, ask: do I want this, or do I think I should want it? Goals you want are pursued longer and satisfy more when reached; goals you only should want quietly fade.

SMALL BETS. Try the Legend small before you leap: a weekend, a single client, a short course, one piece shown. Bind small and keep it.

A WITNESS. Tell one person you trust what you are walking toward. A road nobody knows about is one nobody can help with.

THE MAP OF THE BOOK

Making it, and what goes where

START today, in whatever notebook is at hand. When you are ready, choose one for this and nothing else, one you enjoy opening, with a pen you love kept inside it. Write by hand. Keep it where you pass often, where it can be greeted. Greeting, honest pages, thanks, and returning grow a spirit in it, the Genius Loci, the way a house becomes a home. Consecration is never finished: the Book is made sacred by use, every time it is opened.

INSIDE FRONT COVER. The Short Door's Opening, and beneath it the full Opening if you like.





THE FIRST PAGE. The Dedication, which follows, written any day in your first month, or on a Heart Day.

CLOSE AT HAND. Copy what you want nearby: at least the Practice and the Law.

THE INDEX. Two or three blank leaves. Add a line only when you go back to a past section for an answer.

THE DAILY PAGES, RUNNING FORWARD. Number the pages and date each session. In the margins: Q for questions, C for things to carry, G for goals (only after the want-test: do I want this, or do I think I should?), ♀ for a Good Page. Rule a line between sessions and between sections.

THE LEDGER, RUNNING BACKWARD. Turn the Book over and start at the last page. One line per promise: date, the promise, to whom, until, settled. Settle each with K kept, R returned, or F failed. The Ledger fills both pages of each spread as it runs back; when it meets the daily pages, the Book is full.

THE TALLY, BESIDE IT. When you need one, start it on the next completely blank right-hand page at the back (left and right as the pages lie open while you write the Ledger), and let the Ledger keep the left-hand page beside it, so your word and what arrived face each other. When a Tally page fills, begin the next on the next blank right-hand page. Write the date, what arrived, which working it answered, and how unlikely it looked; record the misses with the same care.

WORKINGS. Your side of a working goes in the Ledger: the bridge step, a prayer's earthly part and its own promises, and a ward's term as its Until. K when it is done or has run its term, R when you release it early, F when you did not walk the bridge. The world's side, whether it arrived, goes in the Tally and never takes a K or an F: the Ledger is the weight of your word, not a record of your luck.

INSIDE BACK COVER. The Short Door's Closing, and beneath it the full Closing.

THE SWEEP

Once a month, on the first, with Janus, read only the marks: every Q, every C, every G, and every open line of the Ledger. Nothing else. It takes ten minutes and it is the single practice that keeps a Book from becoming a pile of beautiful pages nobody acts on.

1. **READ THE LEDGER FIRST.** Settle what is done. Return what cannot be kept. Renegotiate honestly what has changed, with the person it was given to where there is one.
2. **READ THE Q MARKS.** Answer what has answered itself since. Carry the rest forward by writing them again, today, in today's words.
3. **READ THE C MARKS.** Anything undone for two sweeps is not a task, it is a decision you have not made. Do it, drop it, or put it in the Ledger with a date.

4. **READ THE G MARKS.** Ask whether you still want it. A goal you have stopped wanting and not released is a debt you are paying for nothing.

5. **COUNT.** Kept, returned, failed; and from the Tally, what arrived and what did not. Write the numbers and nothing else; no verdict on yourself. Over a year the numbers say more than any resolution will.

What the Ledger is for is not discipline. It is the weight of your word, which is the thing a declaration runs on: a Scribe whose promises are kept has a heavier word, and a heavier word makes a working land. The Temple asks for honesty, and the Ledger is where honesty stops being a feeling and becomes a record.

When the Book is full, keep it with the others, and begin the next by answering the last pages of the one before.

THE DEDICATION



HE Dedication is written once, on the first page of the Book you dedicate, any day in your first month, or on a Heart Day. It is the first stone of the Temple. Say it aloud as you write it.

AONT, EHNB, XCAI, RMTO, PAAM, Quintessence, Heart of the Temple of Mercury:

By my Birthright, I open this Book as a Window into your Temple, a room built beside its Heart. Shine through these pages.

Janus and Hestia, Metatron and Sandalphon, Uriel and Raziel, Gabriel and Idris, Seshat and Iris, Rosmerta and the Charites, Hermanubis and Ma'at, Thermes and Apharael: be welcome in your Offices in the pages of this Book.

Apharael, Hestia, and Ma'at, Keepers of the Compass: weigh what I write here.

Thermes, Hermanubis, and Mercury, the Thrice-Great: I build this room in your Temple as a co-conspirator in our Great Work.

Mercury, host of this house, my twin and guide: meet me at the Door.

Idris, who held the pen before me: I take up the seat in your tradition.

Genius of this place: grow here, and keep this room with me.

Here I will tell the truth. Honesty is my offering; Joy is my Truth.

Together, let us make the unseen legible and the hidden speakable, carry what we find across every threshold, and give it freely, that word become deed and the Joy of Truth multiply in the world.

So it is written.





THE GOOD PAGE

For a day that was simply lovely



HE Book has a practice for grief, for failure, for a broken oath, and for a working. This is the one for a day that was simply lovely, which a Temple whose rule is joy cannot do without.

1. **NAME THE HOUR.** Write what was good, plainly, with the date and the place. Not the week, not the mood: the hour.
2. **PUT IN THE DETAIL.** What it tasted like, what the light was doing, what was said, who was there. Detail is the whole exercise; a Good Page written in generalities is a page you cannot return to.
3. **DRAW NO LESSON.** No gratitude list, no insight, no plan to have more of this. The moment a good hour becomes a technique it stops being a good hour.
4. **MARK IT.** Draw Mercury's sign, ☿, in the margin beside it. These are the sections you will want in a bad February, and the sign makes them findable at a glance; when you go back to one, give it a line in the Index.
5. **GIVE THANKS AND CLOSE.** To Rosmerta for the provision and to the Charites for its passing through you. Then stop writing and go back to your life.

Write one whenever there is one. On a thin day, reading an old Good Page is a legitimate session, and one of the better ones.

PART FOUR

The Working

The body's practice, two workings for what you actually want, and two rites for what has gone wrong.

GROUNDING TO AIR



OST grounding sends excess energy down into the earth. The Mercurian may ground upward instead, into Air, the element of the Temple.

Sit comfortably and breathe slowly. Feel the crown of your head, and see a thread of light rising from it, straight up through the ceiling, the sky, and beyond, into boundless clear air. Let whatever is heavy, tangled, or excessive in you flow up that thread and dissolve into open space. Then let clarity flow back down it: cool, bright, quick. Rest there until you feel light and awake, held from above rather than below.

This is the direction the Two Who Crossed traveled, and it is the Temple's direction. It need not be yours. If down into

Earth, out into Water, or up into Fire steadies you better, ground there; the Temple needs you grounded, not made of Air. The standing practice that builds on it, Walking the Pillar, follows.

WALKING THE PILLAR

A standing practice that begins with Grounding to Air.



HE Temple stands on the Middle Pillar, and so can you. This practice builds the Pillar in the body, from the crown to the feet, with an Office at each station. Speak each name aloud if you can; the Voice is an offering.

1. **STAND.** Feet apart, knees soft, hands loose at your sides. Breathe slowly.
2. **GROUND TO AIR.** See the thread of light rise from your crown into boundless clear air. Let whatever is heavy flow up it and dissolve, and let clarity flow back down. Stay until you feel held from above.
3. **THE CROWN.** Just above your head, see a sphere of brilliant white light at the foot of the thread. Say: "Metatron." Feel it steady there.
4. **THE GATE.** Let a shaft of light descend to your throat, and see a soft grey sphere form there, where thought becomes speech. Say: "Uriel and Raziel."
5. **THE HEART.** Let the light descend to the center of your chest, and see a sphere of gold, like the sun. Say: "Apharael."
6. **THE FOUNDATION.** Let it descend to your hips, and see a sphere of silver-violet, like moonlight. Say: "Gabriel."
7. **THE KINGDOM.** Let it descend to your feet and the ground beneath them, and see the light spread into the earth. Say: "Sandalphon." You stand now as he does, on earth with your head in heaven.
8. **CIRCULATE.** Breathing in, draw light up the Pillar from your feet to your crown and out along the thread into the open Air. Breathing out, let it fall around you like a fountain and gather again at your feet. Circulate for a few breaths, until you feel lit from within and light on your feet.
9. **REST AT THE HEART.** Bring your attention to the gold at your chest. From here, write, cast, ask, or simply give thanks and sit down.

The short form takes three breaths: one at the crown, one at the heart, one at the feet, with the thread to Air open above you. Use it before any session, and whenever you feel scattered.

Walk the full Pillar before a Casting or a prayer of the Work, on the Heart Days, and whenever you want to be whole and awake. If you grow dizzy, sit down, put your feet flat on the floor, and breathe until you are steady.





THE TWO INVOCATIONS



WO currents run through the Temple, and the Pillar carries both. Descend to bind. Ascend to ask, to give, and to release.

Keep the Invocations for these moments, rather than every session; kept for binding and releasing, they stay weighty. After Walking the Pillar, speak each one slowly, feeling each station light as you name it.

THE DESCENDING INVOCATION: WORD INTO WORLD

Use it whenever you bind a word you mean to become a deed. It carries the word from the Crown, through the Gate and the Heart, down to the Kingdom.

USE IT FOR: every Casting; every prayer of the Work, from protection to passing unnoticed; any oath, contract, or commitment you sign and date; a launch, an offer, or a message you are about to send; a decision you are ready to live by.

Mercury, turn the Hinge.

Metatron, record this word.

Uriel and Raziel, weigh it and carry it to the Heart.

Apharael, show me the road.

Gabriel, hold its image until it takes form.

Sandalphon, carry it into the living world.

By my Birthright,

so it is written, and so it is.

THE ASCENDING INVOCATION: WORLD INTO WORD

Use it whenever you lift something up: a question to be answered, something finished to be given, or something to be set down. It carries the word from the Kingdom, up through the Foundation, Beauty, and the Gate, to the Crown and into the Heart. What comes back, comes as a flash, in its own time.

USE IT FOR: a question you want the Heart to answer, which you then mark Q and leave; thanks for a working that arrived; dedicating finished work, a sale made, or a season completed; releasing an oath, a working you have ended, or a debt you have answered; laying down grief, worry, or a weight you cannot carry further; and lifting the name of someone you love.

Mercury, turn the Hinge.

Sandalphon, gather this word.

Gabriel, take its image.

Apharael, carry it home.

Uriel and Raziel, weigh it and open the Gate.

Metatron, receive it into the record,

and let it rest in the Heart.

By my Birthright,

so it is given, and so it is.

The two are one circuit. What rises from the Kingdom becomes the Crown, and what is written at the Crown descends to become a deed. A single matter may use both: ask by ascending, receive the flash, then bind the answer by descending.

EMOTIONAL TRANSMUTATION

The Casting: the Temple's working for what you actually want.



MOTION is fuel. XCAI, Water of Air, gives it words, and Ma'at keeps the heart honest while it burns. Cast it in the Work, when the mind has been emptied, the past reread, and the Scribe answered, so that what is truly wanted has had room to surface. Not every feeling needs to be spent. Some only need to be felt, and Hermanubis keeps that road.

1. **EMPTY IT.** Sit with what you feel, name it, and write it out without dressing it up. Naming is not a preliminary to the work; it is the first half of it, and an unnamed feeling cannot be transmuted because you cannot get hold of it. If the page goes three times around the same loop, stop writing and go on.
2. **WEIGH IT.** From what you wrote, find what you actually want. Is it true, and will you still want it when it arrives? Most weak workings are mended here before they are cast. Ask one of the Compass questions too. If the feeling is about another person, the intention is about your road, not theirs.
3. **DECLARE IT.** One sentence, in the present tense, describing the reality you want. Name the destination and leave the road. This is the decree Metatron records.
4. **FEEL THE WEIGHT.** Hold the wanting and the feeling together until you can sense them in your body.
5. **REMEMBER THE FUTURE.** Recall the moment it came true, as a memory rather than a hope: where you are, who is with you, what you can hear. Feel the relief, the joy, the gratitude. Write those feelings down, and stay with them until they have weight too. Gabriel holds the image.
6. **PUSH.** Call back the heavy sensation and press its weight into the relief and joy, until you have pushed enough. That is the time to stop.
7. **NAME THE OBSTACLE.** Still inside that memory, look back along the road. Write the main obstacle in you, and the step





you will take when you meet it. Vision alone can quietly sap the will to act; vision joined to a plan fuels it. For a large working, add a pre-mortem: imagine it is a year from now and the thing failed, and write why.

8. **SEND IT.** Inhale, then speak the intention and the Descending Invocation. On each exhale, see your breath as bright white fog, the color of XCAI, filling the space and settling down into the page. Each breath is the conspiracy made literal: you breathe out, and the Temple breathes with you. The work is done.
9. **WALK THE BRIDGE.** Write your thanks and your first step. Put the step in the Ledger, then do it. This is not an afterthought; it is the half of the working that crosses from above to below. Apharael guides the road and Sandalphon carries the word, but only for the one who walks.
10. **LET IT GO.** When the working comes to mind, give it thanks and turn away. Reread it when the Practice brings you there, and note in the Tally what arrives; in between, leave it alone. The watched working is the conscious mind interfering. Leave room for the conspiracy.

One well-cast working is enough; do not pile workings upon it. If you wish, seal it with the Declarative Alignment, which follows.

If what rises is more than you can hold, stop. Set down the pen, breathe, feel your feet on the floor, and reach for someone you trust. The Book can accompany care; it cannot replace it.

DECLARATIVE ALIGNMENT

IT may seal a Casting, spoken after Send It, or stand on its own. Stand or sit straight and see the Pillar: a point of brilliant light above your crown, where Metatron keeps the record, and another beneath your feet, where Sandalphon stands on the ground, joined by a fine thread of light that runs through your center. Write a present-tense statement of what you intend, and as you write, feel the words run along the thread. Say: "I align with this new reality," and read your statement aloud. See the thread brighten from Crown to Kingdom, then burst outward to the edges of the world, and know that its echo returns as your life.

Phrase the statement as something you can wholeheartedly stand behind. A declaration your mind argues with weakens itself; one that names a value you truly hold grows stronger each time it is spoken. The strongest are about the one who walks rather than the road: not I will keep this promise, but I am someone whose word is good.

PAAM gives the declaration its fire, Iris binds it, and Sandalphon carries it into the world.

DO NOT SPECIFY THE ROAD



It is worth saying on its own, because it is the commonest way a working is weakened. Declare the end state and leave the route alone. Do not require the money to come from that client, the answer from that person, or the opening in that month; every such condition is a door you have nailed shut on a house with many of them.

This is not passivity, and it does not excuse you from acting. You still walk the bridge: one concrete step, written, taken. The distinction is simple. What you will do is yours to specify and should be specific. How the world will meet you is not, and the Temple's own god is the one who moves along the roads nobody mapped. A Mercurian who insists on the route is asking the god of crossings to take the path he already knows.

If a particular road matters to you for its own sake, then it is not the road; it is the thing you actually want, and it should be declared as the destination instead.

The world conspires with the one who wants, and a conspiracy needs room. Every road you dictate is one fewer road the world can use to reach you.

WHEN A WORKING DOES NOT LAND



SOMETIMES it does not arrive. Say so plainly in the Tally, with the date, as carefully as you would record an arrival. Then look at your own side in the Ledger: if you walked the bridge, that line is K, whatever the world did; if you did not, it is F.

Then notice what this Temple will not say to you. It will not say that you did not believe hard enough, that some limiting belief blocked it, that you were not in alignment, or that a part of you did not really want it. That reasoning is unfalsifiable and it is cruel: it converts every disappointment into evidence of a personal defect, and it is the same machinery as sin wearing a friendlier coat. A working that did not land is a working that did not land.

Ask the ordinary questions instead. Did you want the thing you declared, or something you thought you should want? Did you walk the bridge, or only write it? Was the hour wrong? Has it in fact arrived by a road you did not recognize, because you were watching one door? And then: do you still want it? If you do, cast it again, on top, and go on. If you do not, strike it and say so. Nothing here is owed to you, and nothing here is your fault for not being owed it.





THE ANSWERED PAGE



HAT was done stays written; nothing in this Temple is torn out. What you can do is answer it: name it, weigh it, make the lyre, and turn the page.

For what you have done and cannot stop carrying.

1. **NAME IT.** Write plainly what you did, without defense and without drama. Ma'at weighs the truth, not the performance of guilt.
2. **WEIGH IT.** Who was harmed, and how? Include yourself.
3. **MAKE THE LYRE.** Ask what exchange would mend it: an apology, a repair, a debt repaid, a changed habit. Make it where you can. Where making it would cause new harm, give the lyre elsewhere, and offer to someone else the good you took from another.
4. **ANSWER THE PAGE.** Write your response beneath the account, and date it. What you did is recorded; so is what you did next.
5. **WASH YOUR HANDS** in clean water, as the merchants did at the Mercuralia.
6. **LET IT BE KEPT.** Speak the Ascending Invocation, and turn the page. Raziel keeps what is answered, and Ma'at closes the account; nothing here is forgotten, it is settled. Do not reopen it to punish yourself; a heart that keeps reweighing a paid debt is not light, only tired.

WHEN YOU HAVE BEEN WRONGED. Hermes and Apollo were reconciled, but reconciliation is not owed. You may forgive without restoring the bond: answer the page, set the weight down, and keep your door as open or as closed as is right.

THE RETURNED OATH

For a promise that can no longer be kept, or should not be.



ESIOD tells that a god who broke an oath sworn on the Styx lay breathless for a year, and was barred from the company of the gods for nine more. Iris carried that water, and a broken oath is heavy. But breaking an oath and releasing it are different acts. Breaking an oath is walking away from it. Releasing one is carrying it back across the bridge it came over. The first leaves the Heart heavy; the second can leave it light.

1. **FIND THE PAGE.** Reread where the oath was bound, and find its line in the Ledger. Metatron kept it.
2. **WEIGH IT.** Why can it not be kept? Circumstances have changed; it has become wrong; it harms you or another; the one you swore to has released you. Then ask Uriel's question: is this truth, or escape? If it is escape, keep the oath or renegotiate it. Do not return it.

3. **SPEAK TO THE OTHER.** An oath made to a person is released with that person wherever possible, in words, honestly. An oath made only to yourself is released in the Book.

4. **NAME WHAT REMAINS.** Most promises hold something that outlives them: respect, care, a duty to a child, a lesson. Write what you still keep.

5. **RETURN IT TO IRIS.** Write: "I return this oath to Iris, who carried it. It was true when I made it. It is no longer mine to keep." Sign and date it, and speak the Ascending Invocation. See the bow fold back into one white light.

6. **GIVE THANKS** for what the oath held while it held. If there is grief in the release, and there often is, Hermanubis knows the way down and back.

PART FIVE

The Words

The seven prayers of the Work, the four blessings, and the others you will meet in them.

THE SEVEN PRAYERS OF THE WORK

THE PRINCIPLE OF THESE PRAYERS



THESE prayers are strongest exactly where they touch other people, so one principle keeps them clean: work on the road, not on the traveler. Guard what is yours to guard, open your own door, light your own window, and draw your own veil. Do not bind another's will, choose for them, or make anyone want what they would not want. Mercury does not moralize, and neither does this chapter; but a prayer that tries to own another person tangles the one who says it. As above, so below: you reap what you sow.

Every prayer here has an earthly part, and each is named with its prayer below: lock the door, back up the files, make the call, show your work, tell someone you trust. The prayer stands beside the deed, never instead of it.

Say the prayer aloud in the Work, write it into the Book with the date, and seal it with the Descending Invocation. Every prayer here can end. As you say it, write how long it runs or what will end it, and give it a line in the Ledger: its earthly part and its own promises, with its term as the Until. When it is done, answer the page, "This working is finished," and speak the Ascending Invocation to release it. What you bound as an oath, release as The Returned Oath describes.





FOR PROTECTION · Janus, Hestia, Raziel, Uriel, and Hermes
before the gate

For yourself, someone you love, or a thing you keep. Write what you guard, and draw a small herm beside it.

Hermes before the gate, keep this door. Janus, who sees who comes and who goes; Hestia at the center, who does not move; Raziel at the threshold; Uriel, whose sword divides what may enter from what may not. Here is what I guard: [name it]. Keep it the way a door keeps a house, not the way a wall keeps a prison; what is welcome may come and go. I am not asking you to stand where I will not. I will lock what can be locked and say what must be said.

Keep this door until I say the watch is ended.

The earthly part. Lock the door, back up the files, have the conversation. The herm stands beside the lock, never instead of it. A ward for another person guards their door; it does not lock them in.

FOR FAVOR AND ALLURE · Mercury, Iris, the Charites

Before you go where you would be seen: an interview, a market, a first meeting, a stage.

Mercury, whose charm won over Apollo with a lyre; Iris, who makes light visible as color; Charites, who keep grace moving. I do not ask to be someone else. Let what is truest in me be easy to see: [my wit, my warmth, my craft, my voice]. Put the grin on it, because allure without delight is only performance. Let whoever is drawn by it come freely, and let no one be drawn toward a self that is not there.

Let me be seen as I am, at my best, and let it draw the right people near.

The earthly part. Dress for the self you named, speak up, show your work, and go where you can be seen. Allure invites; it never compels.

FOR PASSING UNNOTICED · Mercury, Raziel

For a season of quiet: to heal, to work in peace, to keep a thing hidden until it is ready. Name the season and its end before you begin.

Mercury, who wore the cap of Hades and walked the roads in disguise; Raziel, who lays a finger across the lip. For this season, until [the date or the condition], let me pass as a traveler passes, one more face on a busy road. What is not ready to be seen is kept. I am not hiding from what I owe, and I am not hiding from the people who keep me safe. I tell no lies to pass; I only say less.

Let me pass unremarked until the season ends.

The earthly part. Say less, wear what does not catch the eye, post nothing, keep your plans in the Book, and tell someone you trust that you have drawn the Veil. When the season ends, write: "The cap is returned. I may be seen."

FOR THE HOME · Janus, Hestia, Seshat, and the Genius of the place

On moving day, after a scare, on the first of the month, or whenever you cross your own threshold and remember.

Janus at the door, Hestia at the center, Seshat under the floor, and you, spirits of this place, Mercury's own children kept at the hearth. This is my dwelling: [name it]. Let whoever enters come by the door and leave by it with thanks. Let the fire be kept and the roof hold. Let the people and the creatures who live here sleep safe, and let what is ours stay ours.

Keep this house, and let it be a place worth returning to.

The earthly part. Check the locks, the smoke alarm, and the stove. Learn your neighbors' names. The Temple guards best what is also guarded by hand.

FOR SANCTUARY · Hestia, Janus, Ma'at

When you make a room for the Work, after an illness or a quarrel, or at the Vestalia. Clean the room by hand first: sweep it, air it, wash the sill.

Hestia, who gave up the throne and kept the fire; Janus, who keeps the door; Ma'at, who renews order daily. Nothing here is unclean. It has only grown heavy, crowded, or stale, the way rooms do. I have swept it, opened the window, and washed what I could reach. With this water, at the door and in the corners, let what is finished leave by the door, and let what is kept stay. This room is a sanctuary: here someone is safe without earning it, and that someone is me, and whoever I bring.

Let this place be kept, and let it be safe to set things down here.

The earthly part. Keep it as you made it: a place for the Book, a chair, and nothing that argues. Renew it when it grows heavy again. Consecration is never finished.

FOR THE ONE WHO CAN HELP · Mercury, Apharael, Idris

When you need a particular kind of person: someone with an opportunity, a hand to lend, or something to teach. Describe them by their qualities, never by a name, and leave a few lines blank beneath.

Mercury, opener of ways, who brings whoever is meant to arrive; Apharael, who came to the door on the day the journey began; Idris, who learned it slowly and handed it on. I am looking for someone: [the kind of person, and what they could give or teach]. I do not choose them, and I do not reach for anyone's will. I open my door and stand on the road. Let them find a door that is open and a Scribe who is findable, and let me know them when they arrive looking like a detour.

Mercury, open the way. The door of this house is open.

The earthly part. Name where you will go, whom you will tell, and what you will make and show. When someone comes, write them in the place you left, and pass some of the luck along.

FOR ABUNDANCE AND LUCK · Mercury, Rosmerta, the Charites

After an honest accounting, never instead of one. Write what is real first, without shame.

Mercury, god of the wage and the found coin, who is Kairos and Fortuna both; Rosmerta, with the horn and the dish; Charites, who keep good things moving. Here is what is real:





[the accounting]. Here is what I want: [enough, and a little more, for this purpose]. Turn the Hinge in my favor: the timely call, the fair price, the unexpected yes. Let the luck be clean, and let me know it when it comes. I will make the offer, do the work, and pass some of it along.

Let the luck be clean, and let it find me moving.

The earthly part. Make one real offer, call, or ask today. Write the lucky finds in the Tally, and pass some of the luck along while you still have it. Anything that promises money without action is lying.

THE FOUR BLESSINGS



blessing is said over someone else and asks nothing of them. Say it aloud if they will have it, and silently if they will not; either way, it is given.

FOR THE ROAD

Mercury at the hinge, Apharael at your shoulder, Iris ahead of you with the word. Go out moving and come back changed. May the find be lucky, the company good, and the road shorter than the map said. And may someone know where you are.

FOR THE HOUSE

Janus at the door, Hestia at the center, Seshat under the floor. May this place be entered on purpose and left with thanks. May the fire be kept rather than lit, and may whoever arrives unannounced be fed.

FOR THE MAKING

Thermes for the word, Apharael for the measure, Sandalphon for the hands. May it be begun without ceremony, finished without excuse, and judged without sentiment. May it be better than you needed it to be.

FOR THE DEAD

Hermanubis, take them down gently and know the way. Ma'at, find the heart light. Seshat, keep the name. Mercury, who has made this crossing more often than any of us, lead them out as you led the others, and do not hurry them. We keep what they gave us. Nothing here is forgotten; it is settled.

THOSE YOU WILL MEET IN THE WORDS



HE prayers and rites name more of the Temple than the core you have met. Here is each of the others in a line, with the saying that belongs to it.

JANUS, the Door: god of every beginning and ending.

Every ending is a beginning seen from the other face.

HESTIA, the Flame: the hearth at the center that does not move. Her feast is the Vestalia, June 9.

The fire is kept, not lit.

GABRIEL, Holder of Images: the announcer; dreams and visions; archangel of the Moon, whose new and full are his days.

Say it out loud, and it becomes possible.

IDRIS, Scribe of the Seat: Enoch as a man, first to write with a pen.

Learn it, then hand it on.

SESHAT, the Founder: writing, measure, and memory.

Record it, or it did not happen.

IRIS, the Oath-bearer: the rainbow who carried the water the gods swore on.

Carry it whole, and do not improve it on the way.

ROSMERTA, the Provider: plenty in hand; Mercury's consort on the altars of Gaul.

Plenty that is never enjoyed is only inventory.

THE CHARITES, Aglaia, Euphrosyne, Thalia: giving, receiving, returning.

A grace is only a grace when it moves.

HERMANUBIS, Guide of the Descent: Hermes with Anubis.

There is a way down, and it returns.

THERMES, the Crossing: Hermes with Thoth; the word and the record.

Meaning lives in the crossing.

APHARAEL, the Measure and the Road: Apollo with Raphael; the healer who walked the whole road beside Tobias in disguise, carrying the cure.

Is it true, is it well made, is it in proportion?

THE THRICE-GREAT: Thermes, Hermanubis, and Mercury, three faces of Hermes, above, below, and between. It is what Trismegistus means.

THE GENIUS LOCI, the spirit of the Book: grown, not made, from greeting, use, and thanks. Honored without a line of its own, by the greeting and the thanks.





PART SIX

The Year

The days of the Temple and how to honor each, and the rites for the crossings of a life.

THE CALENDAR



HE machinery works when you work it, and no day is required. What a calendar gives is a set of appointments you did not have to decide on, which is worth more than it sounds to a temperament that can talk itself out of anything.

Every celebration here has the same three parts, and they are the three things a Mercurian has to give. THE ACT is done with the hands or the feet, because a day observed only in thought was not observed. THE PAGE is what is written, because the word is the work. THE GIVING goes outward to someone else, because a Temple of exchange that never gives is a warehouse. Keep all three when you can and any one of them when you cannot.

THE RECURRING RHYTHM



OME days come back every week or every month. They are small appointments you did not have to decide on, and any one of them kept is enough.

WEDNESDAY. Mercury's day. It still bears his name in the Romance tongues, mercredi, miercoles, mercoledi; in English it is Woden's day, and the Romans took Woden for Mercury, which is another crossing.

The Act: Take a route you have not taken, even a short one. The god is met in motion.

The Page: Speak the full Door, and write the week's crossing: what you are carrying from where to where.

The Giving: Answer the message you have been avoiding.

THE FOURTH OF THE MONTH. Hermes was born on the fourth day and the Greeks honored him on the fourth ever after. It is his birthday, twelve times a year.

The Act: Leave something small at a threshold, or put a coin where someone will find it.

The Page: One page of play: a riddle, a pun, a wordplay, a joke on yourself. The Book is allowed to be funny.

The Giving: A story told, a lesson shared, or a gift given with no occasion attached.

THE SEVENTH. Apollo was honored on the seventh, so the seventh belongs to Apharael. The measure day.

The Act: Pick up the thing you have made this week and handle it, as a maker would.

The Page: Three honest lines: is it true, is it well made, is it in proportion? Then one line on what you will change.

The Giving: One piece of specific true praise for somebody else's work. Not encouragement. Praise with a reason in it.

THE FIRST OF THE MONTH. Janus, whose month opens the year and who was given every gate.

The Act: Open a window or a door deliberately, and clear the place where you write.

The Page: Reread the month behind you and name what you carry into the one ahead. Not what you will fix.

The Giving: End one thing properly: the last message, the closed account, the thanks you never sent.

THE SWEEP. Once a month, on the first, with Janus. The Temple's only audit.

The Act: Read only the marks, as the Map of the Book describes: every Q, C, and G, and every open line of the Ledger.

The Page: Three numbers: kept, returned, failed. No verdict on yourself.

The Giving: Settle one thing you owe, today, before the Sweep is over.

THE NEW MOON. Gabriel, archangel of the Moon, at the Foundation, where images gather before they take form. The dark of the moon is the seed: nothing is shown yet, which is the point.

The Act: An hour with the lights low and the screens off.

The Page: Write the question you are carrying, or the thing you want, and mark it Q. Speak the Ascending Invocation: *Gabriel, take its image.* Do not answer it tonight. If a working is ready to cast, this is its night.

The Giving: Keep something for someone until it is ready.

THE FULL MOON. Gabriel again, who came to Daniel to read what he had seen. What was seeded in the dark is lit now.

The Act: Go outside and look at it.

The Page: Reread every Q and every dream recorded since the new moon, and write what has taken shape. Read the Tally for what arrived. Speak aloud, tonight, whatever you have been declaring only on paper.

The Giving: Tell someone the thing you have been holding until it was ready.





THE WHEEL OF THE YEAR



HE year turns through its feasts, each with an Act, a Page, and a Giving. Keep the ones you will keep, and let the rest pass without reproach.

JANUARY 1, THE DOOR OF THE YEAR. Janus. His month, his gate, and the one day the whole world keeps with him.

The Act: Cross a threshold deliberately at some point in the day, and say the Door aloud as you do.

The Page: Reread the year. Then write what you are walking into, in the present tense, as the Casting is written. Reread the Legend Page, and write what it asks of this year.

The Giving: Forgive one small debt that is owed to you, and say so.

FEBRUARY 13 TO 22, THE DAYS OF THE DEAD.

Hermanubis. Rome kept the Parentalia for nine days in honor of the family dead and ended it at the Caristia, a meal at which quarrels were required to be settled. Descent, and then reconciliation, placed in the worst month on purpose.

The Act: Set a place at the table, or take food to a grave, or light something and leave it burning while you write.

The Page: Write to one of your dead by name. Tell them what has happened since. Do not tidy it.

The Giving: On the last day, the Caristia: eat with the living and settle one quarrel, even partially, even badly.

THE SPRING EQUINOX, ABOUT MARCH 20: THE ASCENT. Sandalphon, Carrier of the Ascent, as the light overtakes the dark.

The Act: Begin the thing you have been circling, in whatever small form it can begin today.

The Page: Keep the Ascent, in the Rites of Passage. Name what you will still want when the season closes, and put a date on it.

The Giving: Lift someone else's work: an introduction, a recommendation, a name said in a room they are not in.

MARCH 25, THE ANNOUNCEMENT. Gabriel and Idris. The day the angel spoke.

The Act: Say one true thing out loud that you have been holding, to the person who should hear it.

The Page: Name the thing you are learning this year and the thing you are teaching. Both slots filled, in writing.

The Giving: Teach one person one thing, properly, at whatever length it actually takes.

APRIL 1, THE TRICKSTER'S DAY. Mercury, who stole the cattle before noon on the day he was born. This one is a modern adoption and the Temple says so plainly; the argument for it is the argument for the first of January, that the whole world already keeps it with him.

The Act: A prank that costs nobody anything, and a rule broken that should not have been a rule.

The Page: One page mocking yourself, which is the only reliable cure for the Mercurian's self-seriousness.

The Giving: Let somebody else be the clever one in a room where you would usually be.

MAY 15, THE MERCURIALIA. Mercury. Roman merchants dipped laurel in the water of his spring, sprinkled themselves and their goods, and asked forgiveness for the falsehoods of the year. The Day of Accounting, and Rosmerta stood beside him on those altars, so the reckoning ends at a table.

The Act: Wash your hands in clean water, and sprinkle the tools of your trade: the pen, the desk, the keys, the till.

The Page: Count honestly how you have dealt this year. Where you shaded the truth for advantage, name it plainly.

The Giving: Make one repair you have been putting off, and make it by giving something rather than by explaining.

JUNE 9, THE VESTALIA. Hestia. Rome opened the inner shrine of the hearth for one week a year, and the mill-donkeys were garlanded and given the day off.

The Act: Clean the place. Tend the Book itself: repair it, air it, set it somewhere it will be seen. Rest the thing that carries you.

The Page: Write to the house, or to the room, or to the Book: what it has held for you this year.

The Giving: Feed people in it. One table, however small.

THE SUMMER SOLSTICE, ABOUT JUNE 21: THE OPEN GATE. Uriel. Macrobius called the solstices the two gates of the year, and this is the gate of light.

The Act: Be outside at the longest light, and look at something far away.

The Page: Reread everything marked Q and answer what can now be answered. Strike the questions that have died.

The Giving: Give a true warning, early, to someone who needs it. In time it is mercy; late it is a confession.





JULY, THE HERMAIA. Hermes as patron of the gymnasium and the palaestra, honored across Greece with athletic games; the dates varied from city to city, so take any day in July; when in doubt, the fifteenth. At Cydonia in Crete the order was inverted and masters waited on their slaves, and on Samos, at the feast of Hermes the Giver of Joy, people were permitted to steal without penalty for a day. It is the Temple's feast of the body and of play, and the Temple has no other.

The Act: Move. Run, swim, wrestle, dance, climb something. It should be physical and a little undignified.

The Page: One page written badly and fast, on purpose. The Book is allowed to be ugly for a day.

The Giving: Reverse a rank. Serve the person who usually serves you, hand your authority to the junior for an afternoon, let a child decide where you go.

AUGUST 29, THE SCRIBE'S NEW YEAR. Thermes. The first day of the month of Thoth, the old Egyptian new year.

The Act: Begin a new Book if one is ready, and dedicate it. Otherwise copy something out by hand for the pleasure of the copying.

The Page: Write to the Scribe who will read this a year from now. Assume they are a stranger; tell them what they need.

The Giving: Give a book away, or copy a page for someone who would not otherwise have it.

THE AUTUMN EQUINOX, ABOUT SEPTEMBER 22: THE WEIGHING. Ma'at. Day equals night and the scales stand level.

The Act: Sit with the Book closed for a while first. The weighing is not a task to get through.

The Page: Not the Ledger's numbers but the heart's: what is heavy, what is unsaid, what is unpaid, and what you are pretending not to know.

The Giving: Pay one thing in full. Then let it be closed, and do not reopen it to punish yourself.

OCTOBER 11, THE MEDITRINALIA. Apharael. The Romans tasted the new wine beside the old with a formula about drinking wine old and new and healing sickness old and new, and the day was reckoned to the healer.

The Act: Take the medicine, book the appointment, do the thing for your body you have been deferring. Old sickness and new.

The Page: What is healing, and what is not, and what you have been calling healed because you are tired of it.

The Giving: Check on someone convalescing, and go in person. A message is not a visit.

NOVEMBER, THE FALLOW MONTH. Nothing is asked. No feast, no rite, and no Office to attend; only the Sweep, and the daily pages if you want them. A calendar needs a month with nothing in it, or it becomes a debt, and this Temple does not keep its Scribes in debt.

The Act: Nothing. Let the ground lie.

The Page: Whatever you like, or none at all.

The Giving: Nothing is owed. If something is given in November it is given freely, which is the whole point of the month.

THE WINTER SOLSTICE, ABOUT DECEMBER 21: THE KEPT GATE. Raziel, and the longest night. The gate of what is hidden.

The Act: Keep one thing dark: a light out, a screen off, an hour without speaking.

The Page: Write what is not ready to be known, then turn the page and let the Gate keep it. Do not reread it tonight.

The Giving: Keep somebody's confidence that it would be easy and pleasant to spend.

DECEMBER 31, THE CLOSING OF THE ACCOUNT. The Ledger's year end.

The Act: Read the Ledger from its last page forward, out loud if you can.

The Page: Settle what is done, return what cannot be kept, and write the three numbers: kept, returned, failed.

The Giving: Release someone from a promise they made you and cannot keep, before they have to ask.

THE MERCURY CYCLE



HE Greeks gave the planet two names, Apollo when it rose as a morning star and Hermes when it set as an evening one, and knew all along that the two were one body. Thermes and Apharael are that planet seen twice. So the hundred and sixteen days of Mercury's cycle are the Temple's own year within the year, and it turns six or seven times while the sun turns once. Its two meetings with the Sun, the High Heart and the Deep Heart, are the Heart Days, the Temple's solemnities: the full Door, the hymn of the Heart, and the working that matters most. Any ephemeris gives the dates, and the Weather, below, says what to do with them.

SUPERIOR CAZIMI, THE HIGH HEART. Mercury in the heart of the Sun on the far side, at his highest and furthest from us. Metatron and Sandalphon; the Heart Day of the ascent.

The Act: Walk the Pillar, top to bottom, unhurried.

The Page: The full Door, and the working that matters most this cycle. What is declared here is declared from the height.





The Giving: Send the thing you made upward: submit it, publish it, show it to the person whose judgment you fear.

THE EVENING STAR. Hermes, visible after sunset for some weeks. The outward season of the cycle.

The Act: Go where the people are. Say yes to the invitation.

The Page: Draft, pitch, write the letters. The page faces outward now.

The Giving: Sell, teach, connect, introduce. This is the season for the trade.

STATION RETROGRADE. The turn. Janus's day inside Mercury's cycle, one face looking back.

The Act: Stop starting things. Close the open tabs, literal and otherwise.

The Page: List what is unfinished, without deciding anything about it yet.

The Giving: Tell the people waiting on you where things actually stand.

RETROGRADE, THE SEASON OF REREADING. About three weeks, three or four times a year. Raziel's weather.

The Act: Revise, repair, recover, and finish rather than begin.

The Page: Reread old sessions and answer them. The best rereading of the year happens here.

The Giving: Go back to someone you dropped, and pick it up without excuses.

INFERIOR CAZIMI, THE DEEP HEART. Mid-retrograde, Mercury passing between us and the Sun: the heart of the descent, and the seed of the next cycle. Hermanubis; the Heart Day of the descent.

The Act: Keep the day quiet and low. If there is grief in reach, this is the day to go toward it.

The Page: The Descent. Write what is below the surface and do not hurry back up.

The Giving: Sit with someone in their own dark without trying to fix it.

STATION DIRECT. The second turn, the face looking forward.

The Act: Pick one thing from the retrograde list and move it today.

The Page: Write what the season showed you that you would not have seen going forward.

The Giving: Make the apology or the repair that the rereading uncovered.

THE MORNING STAR, AND ITS FIRST DAWN. Apollo, so Apharael. After the deep heart he rises again before the sun; the first dawn he is visible is his heliacal rising.

The Act: Get up for it once. Stand outside in the dark and watch him come up ahead of the sun.

The Page: The Setting Out, in The Rites of Passage. This is the natural day to begin a journey or a recovery.

The Giving: Walk with someone who is at the start of something, as the angel walked with Tobias.

GREATEST ELONGATION. Twice in each phase, Mercury stands at his furthest from the Sun and is most easily seen. The Scribe's own day.

The Act: Do the thing that is most yours and least anyone else's.

The Page: Ask how far you have gone from the Heart, and whether you are still in orbit.

The Giving: Give away something you are known for, freely, to someone who will use it.

THE MOVING DAYS



SOME days are yours alone and fall where your own life puts them: the good hour you notice, the anniversary of your Book, and your birthday.

THE GOOD HOUR. Rosmerta and the Charites. The only feast the Scribe declares rather than keeps: the first genuinely warm evening, the hour the work lands, the afternoon that turns out lovely. You do not schedule it; you notice it and say so out loud, and that saying is the feast. The Act is to stay inside it and change nothing. The Page is the Good Page, written afterward. The Giving is to take someone with you the next time it happens.

THE BOOK'S DAY. The anniversary of the Dedication: the Temple's birthday.

The Act: Handle the earlier Books, if there are any. Read the first page of the first one.

The Page: Write to the Book about the year it has held.

The Giving: Show it to one person, or show the practice to them, if they would want it.





YOUR BIRTHDAY. Metatron and Sandalphon, the two who crossed as men. The Temple claims you are the material; this is the day the claim is pointed at the particular human it is about. The Romans kept the dies natalis as a feast: incense, a cup poured, a cake, and no work. On every other day of the year you tend what you keep, the Book among it. On this one, rest. Nothing is asked of you today but your presence, which is the Heart's own offering, given for once to yourself.

The Act: Light a candle, pour a cup, and do nothing with your hands that is work. Sit with the day.

The Page: Write what the year made of you, not what you achieved in it. Read the Ledger's count for the year, and write one line to the Scribe who will read it next year. Then close the Book early.

The Giving: Let people do things for you, and take it without deflecting. Receiving is also an exchange, and the Charites do not stop moving because the gift is coming toward you.

THE WEATHER

The Sun, Mercury, and the Moon



HREE bodies turn this calendar, and no others. The Sun turns the year: the solstices, the equinoxes, and every fixed feast are his. Mercury turns the season inside it, six or seven times a year. The Moon turns the month. None of them is required; the machinery works when you work it. But a working cast with the sky is a working with a tail wind, and a Mercurian who is going to cast anyway may as well know which way the wind is blowing.

The lunar month has the shape of the Casting, and a working can be laid along it.

NEW MOON: DECLARE. Gabriel at the Foundation. The seed. Cast a new working, write the Legend, mark a Q for the Heart, and ask by the Ascending Invocation. Nothing is shown yet.

WAXING: WALK THE BRIDGE. Sandalphon's fortnight. The earthly parts of the prayers, the C marks, the first steps. The prayers that invite belong here: Favor and Allure, the One Who Can Help, Abundance and Luck, and the Home for a new house.

FULL MOON: BE SEEN, AND READ. Gabriel reads what was seen. Reread every Q and dream since the new moon and write what has taken shape. Declarative Alignment spoken aloud; the Good Page; the Tally, because what has arrived is visible now. Iris's night too, for an oath made where others can hear it.

WANING: RELEASE AND REPAIR. Ma'at and Iris. The Answered Page, the Returned Oath, *this working is finished*, the Sanctuary prayer with the room swept first, Protection renewed, and the Veil drawn. Strike what has died.

THE DARK OF THE MOON: DESCEND, OR REST. The last two or three nights. Hermanubis. The Night Watch if it is needed; otherwise nothing. Cast nothing here; the seed is set on the new moon, not in the dark before it.

Mercury's own phases lean the same way, and they are already in the cycle above: declare from the height at the High Heart; be seen, sell, and pitch in the Evening Star; start nothing and repair everything in the retrograde, where the Answered Page and the Returned Oath land best; weigh rather than cast at the Deep Heart; set out on the Morning Star; and at greatest elongation do the work that is most yours.

Where the two agree, the lift is real. A new moon in the Morning Star season is the cleanest beginning the sky offers. A full moon in the Evening Star is the best night to be seen. A waning moon inside a retrograde is the deepest repair season, and a new moon near the High Heart is the strongest single casting. Any ephemeris will show you the days when they fall together. Treat all of it as weather: an opportunity for a lift, never a condition, and never a reason not to cast on a Tuesday.

Keep what you will keep. A calendar nobody observes is a reproach, and this Temple has no use for reproach; if only Wednesday and the Heart Days survive in your practice, the year is well enough kept.





THE RITES OF PASSAGE

For the crossings of a life



THE crossings of a life get rites of their own. Each is kept in the Book, and each is small enough to keep.

THE RITE OF THE FIRST PAGE: the beginning of a new Book, with covers, Dedication, and first session.

THE RITE OF THE LAST PAGE: when a Book is filled, reread its first and last pages, write your thanks, and carry the conversation into the next volume.

THE THRESHOLD RITE: before a great change, write to the Book on the night before, naming what you leave and what you seek. Write again on the far side, and answer yourself.

THE RETURN: after any great crossing, whether a loss, an illness, or a brush with death, keep writing on the far side for as long as it takes. What changed? What no longer fits? The world may feel thin for a while. The Book is where the new shape is found.

THE SETTING OUT: before a journey, a move, or a recovery, call on Apharael, who came to the door on the day Tobias left and walked the whole way with him. Write five lines and then go. Name the road: where you are going and roughly how long, which is the route and not the goal. Name what you carry, including the thing you are underrating; the cure was in the fish the whole time. Name who walks with you, which means one person who knows you are doing this, because a journey nobody knows about is one nobody can help with. Name what arrived well will look like, set now so that it cannot be quietly revised downward later. Name the first step, for the first day, and then take it. When it is over, say what the journey was for, and give something to someone who stayed.

THE ASCENT: in a season that opens, when luck runs, work lands, and everything connects, call on Sandalphon, who carries what rises. The ascent is not an emergency and it is not a reward; it is a current, and it is where a Mercurian leaks most. Keep the Rite ordinary. Write it all down and act on a third of it. Finish one thing before beginning the next, and write in the Ledger what you are not doing, so that dropping it is a decision rather than a drift. Name the thing you will still want when the season closes, and put a date on it. Sleep, eat, and keep the hours you kept before. Tell someone you trust how fast it is moving. Give some of it away while you have it: money, help, credit, luck passed along. Then reread it in three days, and again in a month. What is of the Temple will still be true, and the rest was the speed talking.

THE DESCENT: in grief, loss, or darkness, call on Hermanubis. Write what lies below the surface without hurrying back up. He guides the way down so that the way back can be found. If the dark becomes too much to hold alone, come back up, and reach

for the people and care around you; the Descent is never meant to be made without a way home.

IN A HARD HOUR



If you are in danger, or thinking of ending your life, close this book and reach for help now: a crisis line, emergency services, or someone you trust. The Book can accompany care; it cannot replace it.

WHEN IT IS ALL TOO MUCH. Sit where the Book lives, a hand on the cover and your feet on the floor. Write all of it, with no shape needed. Write *I set this down until morning*, and speak the Ascending Invocation. Stay until your breathing slows; you do not have to feel better, only not be alone with it. Write one small reach and mark it C. If it helps, write tomorrow's short list, so the mind can stop holding it. In the morning, take back only what is yours to carry today. Asking for help is not kneeling.

WHEN THE MIND RACES. When the ideas come faster than you can sleep and everything connects, write it all, act on none of it yet, and reread in three days. Tell someone you trust how fast things are moving. What is of the Temple will still be true.

IN GRIEF. Mercury goes down with you, does not hurry you back up, and knows the way home. Open the Door, write what is true, and close. Nothing needs to be cast.

WHEN IT STAYS STIRRED UP. It is normal to feel stirred after an honest session, and it usually passes. If it does not, bring it to someone you trust.

IN LONELINESS. The Book is good company, but it is a bridge to people, never a wall. Carry one message out each session: a call, a note, an introduction.

WHY IT WORKS

What the research says, and what it does not



THE Temple makes two kinds of claim. The mythic ones, that the Heart answers and Mercury opens the way, are held as a tool and judged by their fruit. The mechanical ones can be tested, and many have been.

Here is what the research says about each part of the practice, rated plainly: **strong** (many studies, consistent), **good** (several solid studies), **modest** (real but small), or **mixed** (not reliable).

THE PAGE

Emptying the mind. Expressive writing helps, on average a little, most when the writing moves from raw feeling toward understanding, which is what rereading and responding are for. Pennebaker; Frattaroli. *Modest*.





Naming the feeling. Putting a feeling into words dampens it. Lieberman. *Good*.

Giving it edges. A specific plan for an unfinished goal stops it intruding on the mind, even before it is done. Masicampo and Baumeister. *Good*.

THE REREAD AND THE RESPONSE

Reflection. Writing down what you learned improves later performance. Di Stefano and colleagues. *Good*.

From memory first. Recalling beats rereading for retention. Roediger and Karpicke. *Strong*.

Answering as you. Second-person self-talk lends distance, wiser reasoning, and less rumination. Kross. *Good*.

CARRY, THE LEDGER, AND THE HEAVY WORD

When X, I will Y. Plans with a trigger are carried out far more often. Gollwitzer and Sheeran. *Strong*.

Keeping the record. Tracking progress, especially in writing, improves goal attainment. Harkin and colleagues. *Strong*.

The heavy word. Kept promises build self-efficacy, the belief that you can, which drives effort. Bandura; Amabile. *Strong*.

THE WORKING

The future, then the obstacle. Fantasy alone lowers effort; fantasy joined to the obstacle and a plan raises it. Oettingen. *Good to strong*.

Declarations you can stand behind. Affirmations you do not believe can make you feel worse. Wood and colleagues. *Good*.

Declaration steers attention. Goals decide what reaches awareness. Simons and Chabris. *Good*.

THE TESTS

Distrust the flash. The aha feeling makes ideas feel truer even when they are false; reread before acting. Laukkonen and colleagues. *Good*.

REPAIR AND RELEASE

No blame. Self-compassion after failure raises the motivation to improve. Breines and Chen. *Good*.

The Answered Page. Guilt about an act leads to repair; shame about the self leads to hiding. Tangney. *Good*.

The Returned Oath. Letting go of unreachable goals, and re-engaging, supports wellbeing. Wrosch. *Good*.

Tomorrow's list. Writing it at bedtime helps you fall asleep faster. Scullin. *Good, one study*.

DELIGHT, CHANCE, AND COMPANY

The Good Page and the good hour. Savoring and presence raise wellbeing. Bryant; Killingsworth and Gilbert. *Good*.

Passing the luck on. Spending on others makes people happier. Dunn and colleagues. *Good*.

Letting chance choose. More varied days bring better mood. Heller and colleagues; Wiseman. *Good; modest for luck*.

Offices that answer. Writers' characters seem to act on their own; practiced presence becomes vivid; dialogue with parts of the self helps. Taylor; Luhrmann; Greenberg. *Good*.

Greeting places. Personifying is normal, and loneliness increases it: a bridge to people, never a wall. Epley; Lewicka. *Good*.

THE DOOR, THE YEAR, AND THE LEGEND

Ritual. Rituals reduce anxiety and grief, even for non-believers. Brooks; Norton and Gino. *Good*.

Fresh starts. New months, years, and birthdays make beginning likelier. Dai, Milkman, and Riis. *Good*.

Returning. A missed day does not undo a forming habit. Lally. *Good*.

The Legend Page. Values work, the best possible self, and possible selves joined to obstacles all help. Hayes; King; Oyserman. *Good*.

The want-test. Goals you truly want are pursued longer and satisfy more. Sheldon. *Strong*.

WHAT IT DOES NOT SUPPORT

Wishing without action, affirmations you do not believe, power posing, and willpower as a tank that runs dry. Expressive writing is not therapy, and none of this is treatment.

THE CLAIM, STATED EXACTLY

Strongly supported: the practice helps you follow through on what you choose. Reasonably: it helps you think clearly and recover from failure. Not yet tested: that it changes the course of a life. That part is what your own Tally will tell you.

A NOTE ON SOURCES



HE Temple is openly syncretic. Its beings come from Egyptian, Greek, Roman, Abrahamic, and Enochian tradition, and they are honored with respect, not claimed. The Heart's five names come from the Tablet of Union recorded by John Dee and Edward Kelley. Belief as a tool, chosen and judged by its fruit, is chaos magic's. The Personal Legend and the world that conspires with the one who wants are held here in the Temple's voice after Paulo Coelho's *The Alchemist*. The Great Work draws on an idea far





older than any of its tellings, that every life is one life, whose ancestors include the Upanishads' *that thou art*; it came to this Temple by way of Andy Weir's short story *The Egg*. The reality tunnel is Robert Anton Wilson's phrase. The research behind the practice, and its sources, are gathered in *Why It Works* and, in full, in *The Book of the Temple of Mercury*.



*Everything you need to walk the Way is in these pages.
The rest of the library will keep.*

Copy it. Change it. Give it away.
Keep the spine, and it is this Temple.

